

can be made happy by a number of things. Not all of them are the sort we are proud of. Not all of them increase the world's well-being.

Included in the evolved human species' genetic material is a desire to mate with the most attractive partner. We have developed a range of strategies and deceptions for that purpose. Women enhance their bosoms to show what good mothers they would be. Men like to show how rich and desirable they are. Some do this by driving cars they cannot really afford. Some endow hospitals with amounts that are pocket change to them. Some like to show how little money means to them—by tipping the cigar girl with a \$100 bill or blowing a fortune on a worthless painting.

Vanity, vanity, vanity—money talks and bullshit walks. That's just the way we are.

Ted Turner must be as vain as Narcissus. He actually gave the United Nations—the UN!—a billion dollars.

Why on earth would he do such a thing? Wouldn't the world be better off if he used his money to build houses, hotels, and other things people might actually want? Why give it to a bunch of hacks who have never built anything?

But the *grand geste* got his face in the paper. He was happy.

You can see the vanity and competitiveness of it at work at a charity auction. There, the desire to spread your tail feathers is almost irresistible. There is often no relationship between the bids and the object on sale.

In fact, the greater the distance between one and the other, the more it flatters the vanity of the bidder. One fellow bids \$1,000 for a luncheon with a faded sports star. Another bids \$2,000. And then, the *grand geste*: "I'll make it \$10,000. . . ." He struts up to the stage to the enthusiastic applause.

The man is a hero. Is the money well spent? Is the charity worthwhile? Is the result greater wealth/more happiness—or less? Nobody knows. Nobody really cares, either.

That's another problem with charity: The giver is not more blessed; he is a bigger jerk. He cares only about his own status and about his own vanity, not about what harm his money actually does to people.

That's another big difference between other kinds of money and family money. You "give" money to others in the form of taxes. You have no choice. The money is transferred from you to someone else. Many people